





LE!SURE

THROUGH THE AGES
(Clockwise from left) 'Bullock Cart in front of Bombay High Court' by an unidentified photographer; Dev Anand clicked by J. H. Thakker; Chittaprosad's 'The Tram Way Workers' Strike'

EXHIBITION ▼

METROPOLIS, IN MOTION

At DAG Mumbai, BOMBAY FRAMED explores the city's contradictions through art, archives, migration histories and cosmopolitan urban life

Bombay is a city that rewards change, for its almost dogged refusal to slow down and stagnate. It's true—there is no singular way to tell the story of Bombay, because there's a different face of the city that reveals itself every day.

With DAG's *Bombay Framed*: *People, Memory, Metropolis*, the city's contradictions come to the fore. Once a scattered group of seven islets joined by land reclamation, Bombay evolved from a colonial port town into a buzzing commercial and cultural centre. It went from being a trading hub in the 18th century to a site of political resistance during the freedom struggle in the 20th century. "*Bombay Framed* showcases a wide range of material spanning four centuries—paintings, photographs, prints (by Indian and foreign artists), archival material and memorabilia—allowing the city to be seen from multiple vantage points," says Ashish Anand, CEO and managing director of DAG.

The works on display span a wide range of artists—M.V. Dhurandhar, Baburao Sadwelkar, S.H. Raza and Abalal Rahiman, to Pestonji Bomanji, Chittaprosad, Nalini Malani and Henri Cartier-Bresson. So, in order to grapple with the expanse, the exhibition is split into four sections: 'City as a Muse', 'Beyond the Metropolis', 'The Many Faces of a City' and 'The City of Lights/Dreams'. "This visual archive invites us to reflect on Mumbai's history. How should we think of the city?" asks historian Gyan Prakash, the volume editor for the exhibition. "Jonathan Raban wrote that the 'city as we know it, the soft city of illusion, myth, aspiration, nightmare, is as real, maybe more real, than the hard city' one can locate in maps, statistics and sociology."

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Through a rich selection of artworks, archival material, photography and multimedia displays, the exhibition retraces Bombay's journey—its port economy, industrial growth, cosmopolitan inhabitants and the layered histories of migration that have shaped its identity. The accompanying publication advances these narratives through critical essays by leading scholars, writers and cultural commentators. ■

—Arshia

The exhibition is on till April 4